Night Out

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/51737050.

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Teen And Up Audiences

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F/F

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Adora/Catra (She-Ra), Adora & Catra (She-Ra)

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by LonelyBoa

Summary

An overworked Adora is tricked into coming out with her friends and meets a cute bartender.

Silver Lotus

Blue eyes rolled as they paired with a light sigh at the immaturity.

After weeks of rigorous training and postponing nights off with her close knit friend friend group, Adora had finally caved and agreed to a night out. With the understanding that it would be nothing wild, just dinner in the evening and maybe a couple of drinks with the night ending well before midnight.

She knew it didn't reflect her as being adventurous, but when she had early morning conditioning and an upcoming final in her physiology class that she needed to review for with her limited spare time, it was important that she have every moment accounted for when she finally agreed to go out with Glimmer and Bow.

Her choice of clothing was simple, a dress shirt tucked into a pair of black slacks with her red sleeves cuffed at her forearms.

They had *told* her it would just be the three of them, but when the familiar silver sleekness of Glimmer's Malibu pulled up outside of her apartment the spark of her nerves paired with the sight of the backseat made her mouth nearly drop.

Packed into the back was Mermista, Sea Hawk, and Perfuma. Adora enjoyed all of their company, with most of them having been friends since high school and trying to coordinate their schedules to take similar prerequisite classes at the university

when they could, now was not a time that she could say she felt eager to see them already taking up the available room in the vehicle.

Perfuma waved excitedly from the window nearest to her side of the street as Adora unfroze herself to bound down the concrete steps. Once she was close enough, Perfuma opened the door - inviting her in as if there were any room to be spared.

“Hey guys” she greeted her friends in the back before shooting a multipurpose look at the pink haired driver, who knew what the hold of her stare meant.

She was met with a salute from Sea Hawk, the friendly chime of Bow’s “hello”, and the disinterested head tilt from Mermista.

Thankfully they all looked about as dressed up as Adora, clearly given the same set of instructions from Glimmer the Ringleader to wear something nicer than casual. Adora wondered if they knew more about what the night held.

Sea Hawk moved himself more into Mermista’s personal space to allow room for Perfuma and Adora to situate themselves. Nothing about the situation was comfortable, but with the close-knit relationships between the friends, they didn’t mind the close quarters as much as if it would have been a total stranger.

After giving up on the idea of seat belts, Glimmer shifted into gear and pulled away from the safety of Adora's home. The blonde sat in the back, thinking now would have been an okay time to jump.

From what she could see, Glimmer had also dressed up. She would never miss an opportunity to and was decked out in a deep purple sequined dress with a deep V neck and flowing sleeves that flowed down near her elbows as she gently pulled the wheel. Perfuma was also dressed differently, still a floor length dress spilled across the floor of the car in shades of green with the sleeves resting at the sides of her shoulders. Adora shifted her Timberlands to make sure they weren't stomping the garment into a balled up mess beneath them.

Mermista had opted for a similar look to Adora, which gave relief. Her dress pants and open blazer with a deep blue crop top and her waterfall hair pulled into a messy ponytail made her look dangerous.

Before Adora could find the words to speak up, Glimmer spoke over the hum of the car.

"So we *are* going to get dinner but it's at this great place Bow and I have been wanting to try drinks at too…"her words flowed like she expected one of her passengers to dam them up at any time. In the rearview mirror, her sparkling eyes swiped to Adora then back to the road.

"Oh wait, are you talking about that place with the dancing?" Mermista asked, her near lethargic voice made it difficult to

discern if she was irked or interested in the notion. Adora opened her mouth to speak but was cut off by Bow chiming in.

"Yeah, the Silver Lotus. One of my brother's friends opened it about a month ago. Suppose to have a killer menu." Bow looked over at his shoulder. Adora wasn't sure but he looked like he was checking in her expression. He was just as aware as Glimmer was that Adora was apprehensive to leave her house in the first place. Now that the plan had changed, it made her stomach drop and she began to worry about how she would get home. She couldn't risk being held hostage all night while her friends sipped designer cocktails and complained about their jobs.

It was exactly why she didn't want to leave in the first place.

"I can probably stay for a couple drinks but I can catch an Uber or something after that".

Even with the hint of agitation she felt at being conned into the car, she didn't want to be rude to her friends. They meant well in the end. Glimmer, whose hair brushed over her shoulder as her eyes darted back to her best friend.

"Adora look," she started. Adora had to fight to not shake her head immediately. Just from her tone, she could tell that Glimmer was about to give her another speech about her life decisions. She loved her and was just thankful that she kept both hands on the wheel and her eyes on the road. "We haven't seen you in nearly three months. I know this is a little more added on to the

night than we had told you about but I know you're going to have fun."

"It hasn't been three months…" her voice argued with uncertainty. She was still unsure. Had it been that long since she had done something other than work, school, or practice?

"Wait, when was the last time you went out?" Mermista asked, raising an eyebrow. Adora felt a mix of embarrassment and irritation at being called out.

"...when we went to the movies! Like two weeks ago." Adora felt triumphant in her argument until she saw Bow shake his head.

"You canceled, remember? Said you had to pick up extra hours."

Her dark brows furrowed at the back of his headrest.

"No, no. The farmers market last month!" she snapped her fingers as she pointed to Glimmer and then the three in the back with her. "For the expansion of your stand." She looked to a very close Perfuma like she was a lifeline to confirm that she wasn't some work obsessed lunatic with no sense of a homelife.

Perfuma shook her head. "You had conditioning that entire morning and thought you could time your run to go by the market

but it wound up raining that day. I think your team trained in doors or something”.

“The point is: we all miss you and we finally got you out tonight.” Glimmer’s car turned after waiting their turn at the red light as the line of traffic passed them. “You don’t have to stay out till sunrise but please don’t try to rush home”.

“You deserve a break.” Bow added, his voice much more even than his girlfriend’s.

The car had already made its way down the highway, weaving precisely behind other cars to join other vehicles in their lane that was similar to an orderly school of fish.

Glimmer certainly had a plan in place well before this and there was no point in trying to stop it now. They meant well, even if it burned away precious hours that she didn’t have the luxury of wasting.

In the small cave under her heart, she knew she needed a night where she wasn’t eroding away at herself to try and refine her shell into an all-star, straight A, mentor, and top student. Hell, a couple drinks may do her some good to unwind and then she would be more focused once she got home.

“Okay, just dinner and a couple of drinks.” she agreed apprehensive.

“And a song or two…” she thought she heard Glimmer’s voice mumble under the hum of the engine.

Her face must have not relaxed quickly enough, her body bouncing gently against the car door she was jammed up against at the playful push of Mermista who stretched her arm from the other side of Perfuma to make contact with her.

“Lighten up, we’re not going out to see you be a little whiner about having some fun.”

Adora’s middle finger gave a clear sentiment back before Bow changed the bluetooth over to his phone to control the music on the remaining leg of their drive. The upbeat choices in his playlist were easy to see through as he tried to set a tone for the night.

The near spotless car pulled into an already packed parking lot of a restaurant with the upscale sign above with the delicate font of the light reading Silver Lotus. The amount of patrons already made Adora wish she had thrown herself out of the car.

“Before you say anything about the wait, I already made a reservation.” Glimmer announced happily as she pulled into a spot and cut the engine off, smiling at her ability to outmaneuver Adora.

Everyone stepped out of the car, Bow and Glimmer clearly having an easier time than the four in the back who managed to unpack themselves quickly, encouraged by their hunger. Small groups of people leaving and entering the restaurant were scattered in clumps in the parking lot around them.

Bow led the group as they all went for the entrance. Glimmer held back, waiting to walk in step with Adora- who had already slipped her hand into the pocket of her slacks.

"Please don't be mad" the shorter girl whispered to her friend as she snaked her arm through Adora's.

The pair walked behind Sea Hawk and Mermista. Adora chuckled.

"I love you, but you and Bow are a pain in the ass sometimes" she smirked, causing Glimmer to give a small elbow to her ribs as they followed everyone inside.

It wasn't an exaggeration, the place was new and it definitely showed. The furniture and lighting was clear and crisp enough that it would have felt like walking onto a movie set if it weren't tapered and decorated in the more casual style it wore. Adora was relieved it wasn't an upscale place that made her feel underdressed. When she used to go out with her friend's more, she preferred dive bars more anyway. The low hues of red and silver in the corners of the room made the potted plants in front of them show in drastic silhouettes, from what she could see in the main dining room, all of the booths and tables were a deep wooden color and all filled with people.

An area further in and against the wall showed a lengthy bar top, mostly dark and without seats available but the lights from the cabinets lit up the area like it was a showcase to be bragged about. After they waited their turn, Glimmer spoke to the hostess who moved to seat them at a corner booth.

For a newer place, it looked like a lot of people were out of their seats and moving around the room to socialize. Somewhere in the other room, a low ring of steady bass beats flowed and added to the clues Adora was trying to piece together.

"So is this like some dance club hybrid?" Adora asked, looking at Bow from her seat in the center of the group. Officially now, she was trapped.

Bow smirked. "You could say that."

Mermista and Perfuma were already on the second page of fawning over the drink menu and its wide selection while Sea Hawk snuck an arm around his preoccupied girlfriend and bobbed his head to the music that filtered in with the rest of the conversations in the room.

Adora turned her attention to one of the table top flag menus that advertised different events the bar and restaurant would be hosting. Her eyes ran down the list of Trivia Night, Speed Dating, Karaoke, and a Drag Bingo Brunch on the first Sunday of every month…then something in that tight ponytail of hers clicked.

Her head looked back up at her environment, studying the people around them. A vast majority she could now see were same sex couples or in large obvious friend groups looking carefree in opposition to Adora's realization.

"Is this a gay bar?" her voice pitching slightly higher than she meant it. Bow and Glimmer looked at their friend.

"Yeah, but more importantly it's Frisky Friday. They have a DJ and half off drinks." Perfuma added. A waitress had already made her rounds and brought waters to the table before feilding Mermista's questions on margarita customizations.

"What are you guys trying to pull?" Adora frowned at the lead conspirators. Glimmer took her time, giving her order of appetizers before turning back to her blonde friend.

"Nothing! We all just want to have a good time!" she insisted.

"My brother's friend really opened the place and we wanted to see it too. Nobody is trying to trick you, Adora." Bow assured. His words made her feel like she was being paranoid and overreacting. It wasn't out of character for any of her friends to go to any type of restaurants, it wasn't always about someone trying to set her up or put her in uncomfortable situations.

"...well yeah, it's great here but once we eat, I'm probably gonna catch a ride home around ten…"

"Adora, jesus. Just chill out and exist in the moment with us for fifteen minutes" Mermista ordered. "We missed you but you're making it really hard to miss you when we finally see you and then you try to run back home to go do nothing. Work will still be work tomorrow. You have multiple days on the weekend and you need to have some downtime or you'll give yourself an aneurysm."

The waitress came back shortly after to take orders from the rest of the table while Adora sat silent. She knew her friends were right, though some were more rude than others in their choice of wording.

"Alright alright, I'll get something. You got the menu Perf?" Adora asked, looking at her friend across the table.

"Shoot. Sorry I just gave it back to the waitress when she took our order." Perfuma said apologetically.

"It's fine," Adora assured, looking at nearby tables that she could snatch a menu off of. Finally she landed on the bar, betting that it was much quicker than waiting for the waitress to come back. "Be right back."

She stepped up to the table just as a taller, muscular woman with white buzzed hair walked out from the bar to grab another case of

drinks. Adora took a minute to see if there were any signs that could help her out as she waited behind two other patrons.

"Let me guess Princess, White Claw?" a snarky voice purred from across the bar. Adora's head turned back, finally noticing she was up. The smirk on the woman's face allowed her to brush the comment off as a playful jab.

"No, do you have a menu or specials?" she asked, keeping her composure.

Long thick hair outlined the slender sculpt of her arms. She bent over to put a clean stein back on the shelf. "Yeah, I got both of those things. But I don't think you'd know what to do with it." her black nails picked up and slid a laminated and lined menu towards Adora. "It's quite the read if you don't know what you're looking for."

Her eyes moved from the bartender, who was intimidating yet almost comforting in her taunts. True to her word, the menu had dozens of selections under just the wine and spirits section alone. Adora wasn't sure what she wanted but knew she didn't want to look sheltered.

"What would you recommend then?" she asked cooly, hooking one forearm over the other on the table top and looking at the barkeep who Adora just realized had one iris in piercing yellow and the other in a cool blue. She paused to think, her hands pulling a loose strand of wild hair behind her ear before moving to grab the required glasses.

Adora didn’t interrupt. Her eyes followed the movements of a professional who seemed in her element as she expertly poured the desired amount of what looked like rum and fruit syrup. Her dark skin complemented the golden shaker that she raised to just above her shoulder and began to mix the liquids in even motions. Adora looked back to her friends who looked like they were having a great time watching her do something other than complain. Bow flashed a thumbs up that Adora spun her back to.

“Alright, it’s called a Hurricane. I put a little spin on it but I think you look like the kinda girl that likes fruit anyway.” the bartender winked at her as she strained the brightly orange colored drink into a shapely hurricane glass. She leaned down to pop open a minifridge and pull an orange slice and strawberry out to garnish the rim of the drink. It looked and smelled great.

“Sweet, how much do I owe you?” Adora asked, wrapping her fingers around the glass. Narrow shoulders shrugged under her curtain of hair.

“It’s on me. Enjoy, oh and it’s a little strong so watch out.”

“Think I can’t handle it or something?” Adora challenged, half joking with the worker.

“Just a fair warning” she raised her eyebrows playfully with her hands up. Her velvety voice was almost as smooth as the cool drink as Adora took a sip. “You seem like the type that would

probably go for a beer or whatever. These will hit you harder than that."

Adora scoffed at the thought of this girl already trying to nail down what *type* of anything she was. Looking at her glass, she didn't realize she was already half way through her hurricane.

"I'm actually the type that got pressured by her friends to fucking loosen up, is what I am." Adora admitted, taking a long pull from the straw of her drink.

The almond eyes looked her up and down before offering her a hand from across the bar. "I'm Catra by the way." Adora smiled and straightened herself to accept.

"Adora."

"Well Adora, I'm glad you came out tonight. I'll give you a shot for the road, it looks like your friends want to steal you away from me."

Catra cleared her now empty glass away before pulling out two clear shot glasses and filling them with what looked like off colored lemonade. Catra pulled a drink to her own hands before pushing a drink to Adora and raising it.

"Have fun tonight, Princess."

The two grinned before tossing their shots back and tapping them back to the counter. Adora walked back to her table, unable to stop herself from turning back around to smile one more time but her new acquaintance had already moved to the left side of the bar to scoop ice for another customer.

Adora slid back up in her seat, already feeling the effects of her drink.

"Excuse me, what was *that* ?" Glimmer asked, leaning on her elbow to move closer to her friend.

"What?"

"Don't *what* me! Notice how you didn't come back with a menu or a drink?" Glimmer noted with accusation.

"I'm good now, I got one up at the bar." Adora said, blissfully unaware and hooking a thumb over her shoulder as if they hadn't just seen her up there after she had verbally dismissed herself from the table.

"No shit, we wanna know about you and Miss Drink Mixer up there." Mermista demanded, with Sea Hawk looking very interested at her side.

Adora used the back of her hand to wipe at her chin, though there was nothing there to wipe. "Yeah, her name is Catra. She's pretty good. She gave me this awesome drink sample." Her friends looked at her with a mixture of irritation and anticipation for more details.

"....That wasn't a sample. Sounds like she was flirting with you." Bow informed his friend who seemed to be missing very clear hints. Adora's lip curled as she rolled her eyes.

"Yeah, you were up there for a while," Perfuma agreed. "I think she likes you."

"Pretty sure I counted two drinks…" Sea Hawk added.

The group was all buzzing when the waitress brought their food. Adora, realizing again that she was behind on ordering, but now craving more handmade drinks from Catra so she would have an excuse to talk to her more.

"She was nice, but it's probably like good customer service." she said, both trying to convince herself and her friends.

Between bites of their food, Bow and Glimmer tried to concoct a plan to trick the bartender to come over to the table. All of which were critiqued by Mermista, who insisted that Adora should just ask for her number already. Both avenues sounded like good strategies to Adora, who was growing bold enough to just go back up to her post and order another drink.

From the other room, they could hear the DJ announce that they were ready to take requests for karaoke and dancing. The announcement made Glimmer light up.

"You and Sea Hawk should definitely sing Hot N' Cold" Glimmer giggled, prompting her friend to respond that she wouldn't be singing shit. Perfuma said that she was unsure about singing but was very eager to dance.

The beat made Adora begin to bob along with it as she snuck bites before she could order her own plate. The drinks had played their part in loosening her up, making her much more agreeable to having more. She asked the waitress for another, then watched as Catra shook it up in the same way she had before then looked in Adora's direction as the waitress ferried it over to her table. Catra gave a wave with her fingers, making Adora blush and look away like she was a teenager again. She was relieved her friends missed that exchange.

Once their plates were finished and cleared away, the group left their tip and moved to claim a table in the other room near the dance floor that was now much busier than what the restaurant side had been. Lights flashed and spun as they lit up the room to match the rhythm of the music. As they sat, Adora spoke up again.

"Hey, I'll go grab us some shots!" she yelled above the pounding bass.

She moved back to the other side, feeling her ears adjust to the dulling of the DJ booth.

"Hey Adora" Catra greeted as she saw Adora head up to the bar. "I just can't keep you away, can I?"

Adora smirked. "Just wanted to make sure you weren't lonely." she tried to quip back "Can I get a round of shots please?"

Catra made quick work of filling the shots and placing them on a platter for Adora to carry. Adora pulled her debit card from her wallet.

"Want me to open a tab?" Catra asked, making Adora forget that their entire interactions had been based on service.

"Sure. You think you'll come dance?" Adora asked, pulling a genuine laugh from Catra.

"I'm working."

"So? Take a break." Adora said dismissively.

Catra looked at her, able to surmise that the blonde was well on her way from tipsy. "Didn't you say your friends had to force you

to come out to make you take a break?”

“Hey, you can’t use that against me. You don’t even know what I’m taking a break from.” she argued, accidentally slurring her last couple of words.

“Work? What are you, a personal trainer?” Catra guessed.

“Close, Assistant Coach, school full time, and working as a mentor to the underclassmen in the lab.” she counted on her fingers as she listed off her titles.

“Glad you could find time to grace me with your presence. I think your friends were right to make you take a night off.” Catra spoke, looking up at Adora with her eyes making her look irresistible. “You go to the University?”.

“Yeah, you?”

Catra shook her head. “Nah, I wasn’t really the college bound type. I pretty much got this gig thanks to my roommate.” She nodded to the other bartender in red with the white hair.

Adora’s face dropped. “Oh shit, I’m sorry if you guys are like- I didn’t mean-”

“Me and Scorpia?” Catra scoffed “She probably wishes…” she whispered around the back of a flattened hand. “No, we’re just friends. And co workers now I guess.”

“Nice.” Adora said. Immediately embarrassed at her one word response.

Was it nice that they weren’t a couple?

“If you get brave, maybe try out the new karaoke system. I heard they just got an upgrade.” Catra called as Adora scooped up her tray to return to the other room where her friends were.

“You’ll be the first to know.” Adora joked.

Through each small conversation they had, Adora could relax in the feeling of how natural it felt. It didn’t drain her the way speaking to other people had. She hoped Catra’s shift would end while they were still here so she could join them over on the dance floor side of the facility.

“Order up” Adora announced as she set down the tray. Each friend reached for a shot.

“Get that number yet?” Mermista asked. Adora shot her a look.

“To my friends, for making me come out tonight. I’m glad you did and I love you guys.” the blue eyed woman raised her glass in a toast, followed by the rest of her friends who either smiled in response or gave a whooping cheer. The six of them took their shots, Perfuma making a deep guttural sound in reaction to the liquor sitting over her tongue a little too long. Glimmer pulled at Adora before she had time to set her glass down.

“Let’s dance!”

The group took turns cycling from the table to the dance floor. Adora had forgotten what a good dancer Bow was and even Sea Hawk managed to pull Mermista on to the dance floor for a few songs.

Other dancers began a queue for their turn to sing with the microphone. Many couples opted for duetting, which made Bow and Sea Hawk agree to sing their own version of some sea shanty chant they had heard at a Frat party.

Glimmer eventually took her turn, with an increasingly inebriated Adora being her number one fan on the dance floor by cheering her on throughout her entire set. Nobody’s voice was star quality, but everyone was in such good spirits that it didn’t matter. Adora hadn’t felt this good in a long time. Confidence bubbled inside of her every time another woman came to dance with her and even more when she would wander to talk to the cute staff member.

Perfuma laughed that Adora should give singing a try, which Glimmer fully supported. Adora almost considered it, but after all

of the dancing, sweating, and food, her stomach suddenly felt queasy. Her face dropped and she felt the excess saliva build up in her mouth. Perfuma turned to say something to Bow and Adora rushed to the bathroom with her fist held over her mouth.

In the sudden calm of the bathroom, the room felt like it was pulsing. Without the distraction of the lights, Adora realized that her environment didn't sit level the way it should. The dark tile of the bathroom and golden faucet sets were a beautiful setting. She paused at the sink, feeling the need to count the stalls in her drunken state to make sure they were empty.

"Shit, this place is nice…" she mumbled to herself, letting her words echo in the bathroom as she looked from the sway of the walls to herself in the mirror. "You got this, you're good. We're not even going to puke." Adora pointed at herself in the mirror. She held eye contact with herself, feeling like it was actually successful in calming her stomach.

"How's it going Princess?" a voice called from the doorway. Adora yelped at the surprise of having someone watching her.

"Don't- don't do that!" she stuttered. Catra crossed her arms and moved closer to a slightly more disheveled looking Adora.

"Ha, sorry. I didn't follow you I swear. My shift is almost over though." Catra said, looking Adora up and down and opting to change the direction of the conversation. "You're gonna be sick, aren't you?"

“Wild fact: Actually I’m not.” Adora told her matter-of-factly. She placed both hands on the counter to brace herself on the sink.

“It’s cool if you do. I did when we had Half Off-Flight Nights. Wine just fucks with me.” she admitted cooly.

A moment of silence with only the muffled beat of the music gave Adora time to filter the mess she had in her brain from coming out of her mouth.

“All good, we’re all good.” she flashed the okay sign with her thumb and forefinger. “But I gotta know…are we all good?”

“Who?” Catra asked, looking confused looking up at Adora. “Us? Yeah. I gave you drinks and you tipped well. I think you’re cool.”

Adora pumped her fists back towards herself in victory. “Hell yeah, I think you’re cool too.” she grinned. Catra curled a fist under her chin, looking very amused at the open compliment from Adora.

“How are you getting home tonight?”

“Don’t even worry. I rode with my best friend Glimmer. And Bow. And Mermista. And Entrapt- wait no. Sea Hawk, and-”

“Christ, did you all come in a school bus?” Catra teased. Adora shook her head hard enough that her ponytail swung.

“Nah, Glimmer’s car.” she burped, holding a fist in front of her mouth before a gagging noise escaped from her throat. Catra’s face went from one of entertainment to actual concern.

“There’s like six of you, what if you get sick on the way home?” Catra asked, watching Adora switch from fine one moment and eyeing a stall the next.

“I could do an Uber. I’m not too far from here.”

“Me neither, if you and your friends are fine with it you could crash at my place.” the offering sounded enticing, but Adora was determined to prove she was fine.

“I’ll be good, I’m just gonna hang out in here for a bit and then- then I will be ready” she repeated with full confidence.

The bathroom door opened again with another woman coming in to enter a stall and Glimmer walking in close behind.

“There you are!” she said with relief “Did you puke?”

“Nah but I’m working through it now.” Adora waved a hand at the line of stall doors. Catra looked at Glimmer.

“Hey, I’m Catra. I work at the bar in the restaurant and I told Adora if she needed a place tonight, she was welcome to stay with me. I live like a block away.”

Glimmer looked at Catra and then Adora. A plan was coming together in her own faded mind but she was her mothers daughter and didn’t feel entirely comfortable letting Adora just stay at a stranger's house.

“I think we’ll be okay. She can hold it together-”

Another gag sent Adora into a stall. “She said that you all rode together, I just didn’t want her repainting your interior with mixed drinks. I can give you the address, it’s just me and my roommate in our apartment. She’s the other bartender here, you probably saw her. I still have to close out her tab." she topped her head back towards where Adora was.

Adora couldn’t make out the rest of the conversation. She seated herself next to the bowl, battling the urge to empty her stomach. She must have been more tired than she thought because she had to catch herself from tipping against the wall of the bathroom as her eyes fought to stay open.

“Hey, you good?” Catra called through the door.

Adora slapped a hand against the wall, fumbling the chrome slide lock before opening it and letting the door swing open. Catra was just outside the door, now stooping down to talk to her.

“I’m good. Not sick. Just resting my eyes for a sec.” Adora swayed. Catra gently caught the side of her head in her hand to slide her back from the wall. The brunette remained staged in front of Adora, still nearly seated in front of her with both hands resting on the sides of her face. She had a relaxed smile on her face and barely wore any make up. Even when she would be primed to look like a fool, Catra felt a flutter in her stomach at being near her and seeing those lips up close.

“Don’t rest them too long. You’re gonna pass out and I don’t want to ask Scorpia to drag your ass home.” Catra said, straightening her legs and pulling Adora’s limp arms into hers. “Come on, you’re coming home with me.”

Alarm bells sounded in Adora’s mind. The immediate excitement of going to a beautiful woman’s home and then the safety officer that assured her that stranger danger was an actual concern, even if you would probably comply with whatever the person asked anyway.

“No, Glimmer is- she was gonna drive?” Adora’s words lost their drive as she looked around the now open stall door of the bathroom. She swept the room, looking for pink hair.

“Already got her blessing for the night.”

“Oh.”

Adora knew that she could be over cautious sometimes, but if Glimmer had given Catra the okay to have her over then she must have deemed her as someone safe, which would have made sober Adora relieved.

Through some directed instruction from Catra, Adora got to her feet and promised repeatedly that she didn’t have to throw up.

The duo almost made their way out of Silver Lotus without incident until they reached the front door and Adora almost tipped herself over on a large potted plant. Catra’s feet moved quickly to pull her back up, causing Adora to rest her arm over her shoulders.

“Tell Scorp I’m headed home.” Catra told the girl at the hostess booth. Adora leaned a head into her, causing a wicked smile to spread on the hostess.

“Want me to tell her to wear earplugs from the front door onward?” she snickered, getting great delight from the implication.

“Shut the fuck up Lonnie.” Catra shot a glance and pushed the door to direct Adora out with her. Thankfully, Adora wasn’t total dead weight and her legs seemed to work in stride with Catra’s when she moved.

The first block made Catra wonder if Adora would pass out as soon as she dropped her onto the couch. Then the second block was filled with Adora asking Catra if she had ever ridden horses before and then throwing together a make-shift plan on how they could make it happen, even in the absence of input of any kind from Catra.

The street was lit up around them and even with strangers giving odd looks to a clearly intoxicated and loud Adora, Catra could acknowledge that it felt nice to have someone’s arm around her who seemed to be very set on seeing her again after this night.

She led Adora up the steps of a large brownstone that was in some need of masonry work but was comfortable for two people who lived on income from a restaurant. Catra had been so proud of herself when she figured out a roommate situation and signed the lease to get out of the same house as her foster mother.

She wriggled out from Adora on her left side to fish for her key, trying to help Adora lean against the secure bricks on the exterior wall and not risk falling down the stairs or over the thick handrail. When she got the locks disengaged, she called over quietly to her guest.

“Do you need water or anyth-”

Adora’s arms embraced her from behind, wrapping around her limbs eager but carefully around her midsection. Feeling the taller girl behind her immediately frazzled her, making her instinctually try to muscle her way free. Adora held on loosely, leaning the side of her on the back of Catra’s. Scarlet flared across the freckled faced girl's cheeks.

“Come on, weirdo” Catra slipped her hand into Adora’s to slowly lead her in.

Catra's Apartment

Chapter Summary

Catra brings Adora home for the evening.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

The two made it through the threshold without issue, Catra for once being thankful that her home was on the first floor unlike previous places that required a hike up flights.

The small entrance way was dark, with a small gray cat snaking its way around Catra's ankles to greet her until it noticed the unfamiliar presence she had brought with her.

"Watch out Melog," she warned carefully, hoping that Adora wouldn't step on him with his flowing movements across the wooden floor. Catra led Adora to the left where the living room opened up. Three angular windows facing the front street let enough light from the street lamps flow through to illuminate their steps. Both the ceiling and walls were the same deep crimson color with older styled crown molding that met its creases. In the shadows, she could see an antique chandelier fixture that almost looked celestial in design. The athletic woman stepped slowly into the room further.

Adora might have tried to be a little more graceful if the situation were different. When she went to sit and nearly missed the entire couch.

“Nice place you got here” she said casually ignoring her lack of coordination.

“Thanks.” Catra called, shrugging off her coat and hanging it back in the entryway before the jingle of her keys rang out as they were tossed, colliding into a small saucer on the end table. “The bathroom is that one.” she gestured with her head to a partially open door that was the closest in the hallway’s options.

“‘Kay.” Adora said. She wasn’t entirely sure what the fuck the plan was from here. She was incredibly more at ease than she would have been without the assistance from the drinking, but it seemed rude to stretch out on her couch and pass out. After the walk to her apartment, sleep was the last thing on Adora’s mind now.

Lost in her own thoughts of admiring the home, she hadn’t realized Catra had walked out of the room. From the couch she could see a wall mounted bookshelf stocked with what looked like historical non-fiction and crime novels. The end table in front of her wasn’t so far gone in the style of a waiting room - there were no magazines to peek at while the minutes slipped from her. The sound of the door down the hall clicking open made Adora jump, worried that she looked like she was on the verge of rooting through Catra’s belongings.

“You want something to eat?” Catra asked, gliding over to pick up the remote from in front of Adora. She was in very small shorts, revealing the full length of her tanned legs. Her top was a black oversized t-shirt that looked perfectly comforting as it encased her

lean body. She kept her eyes on the tv as Adora kicked her mind back into gear.

"Uh, no I'm good."

"You should probably eat more than appetizers and bar food" Catra stopped scrolling to bring her serious looking blue and maize colored eyes to give attention to Adora. "I'm making noodles."

Adora could tell by the statement that a bowl was probably going to be prepared for her even against her insistence that she wasn't hungry. Catra didn't seem like an easy person to argue with, but she did seem like a fun opponent.

"Whatcha watching on Netflix?" Adora's curious voice asked. Catra clicked on Great British Bake Off before walking behind Adora and the couch she sat on into the kitchen area. The room was hardly separated by a large archway where the two could still hear and see each other.

"Just throwing on whatever doesn't require my brain." Catra admitted between the sounds of the rushing stream of water from the faucet and the tunes of a metal pot clinking onto a stovetop. Catra must have flipped a lightswitch from her place in the kitchen, with the lighting immediately making itself available. Adora could see more details of the living room now, intricate ink prints framed on the walls and a handmade afghan blanket covered the other half of the couch she was on.

Two hands pressed down on the back of the couch on either side of Adora, causing her to whip her head around before looking up.

"I hope you don't think I'm forcing you to stay up." she gave a semi-smile down at Adora, whose pulse felt like it somehow had gotten stuck in her throat with the way Catra hovered above her.

"No," Adora shook her head, sounding more meek than she intended to. She quickly cleared her throat. "I- I could sleep through anything."

Her own voice felt like it was barely on a leash. The more she tried to reign in control of what she said and how she said it, the less pull she seemed to have.

"I don't believe that." the brunette challenged. "You seem too uptight to get decent sleep." The weight of small paw's made Adora switch her gaze to her right side to see the cat from before coming to check out the new visitor in their home.

Adora reached a cautious hand out to let the cat give an inspection before she ran her hand across the fur of its side, causing Melog to lean into the touch.

"Uptight? Pretty bold for just meeting someone." Adora smirked, playfully tilting her head up at Catra, who had noticed the favor

her new guess had won with her pet.

Catra shrugged, stepping back and running her hands off the ends of the couch. “Just an educated guess.” She returned back to the stove to check the food that hadn’t boiled yet.

Adora turned back to the quiet voices of the tv, British accents flowed as she watched the pastel colors through the countryside as several bakers worked to perfect a lemon tart recipe. She never watched shows like this, even if it were a cooking competition they usually had more yelling and digital countdown clocks mounted to the wall as the contestants sweat and hurried to finish their creations.

“Do you want a change of clothes?” Catra’s voice rang from over her shoulder. Adora shook her head, causing Catra to groan and roll her eyes. “Follow me.”

Adora listened to the command, being a guest after all. She followed her into a room at the end of the hall where Catra was already rummaging in the top level drawer of a black oak dresser. The room had thick curtains and a plush black comforter covering the queen sized bed.

“You don’t have to do all that,” Adora said, now more uneasy about being *in* Catra’s room.

“Quit being weird.” Catra demanded “Here, I know you’re a little taller but these should be good.”

Catra passed the bundle of clothing to Adora, sliding her body past and out the doorway to return to the kitchen. Adora looked around for a moment, unsure if it was appropriate to change in the room she was left in or if she should go to the bathroom. A bedroom just seemed so much more intimate. She decided to make it quick, pushing the door closed and pulling the belt from her pants before unbuttoning and lowering the zipper to let the fabric slide off her hips and legs. She stepped out of them while working the opening of her button up, making her sway side to side and leaning against the bed to steady herself for a quick second.

Once she opened the button up and shimmied out of the top, she pulled her arms out and put the worn clothes together on the bed before reaching for the gray shirt and pulling her broad arms through.

“Did you want a gatorade to drin-”

Adora inhaled sharply at the voice so close to her as her face was partially obstructed. She couldn’t hear the rest of Catra’s question as her tipsy brain was on high alert to the fact that she was in her panties and half of a shirt that she was in the middle of putting on. She ripped the shirt down, thanking that it was long enough to cover most of where she wanted.

“Jesus, you scared me!” Adora breathed, feeling like her heart was going to pop from her chest. She leaned to grab the sweatpants Catra gave her. Adora was so focused on keeping her head faced

down to hide the deep blush that was painted on her face that she didn't see Catra blink quickly at the exposed and toned body before looking back at the bottle in her hand and shaking herself back into her calm demeanor.

"My bad. Uh- foods done too."

Catra left soundlessly, with Adora left with the soft sounds of clothing as her only solace. It wasn't a big deal, really. Adora had changed in front of girls in the locker room hundreds of times and had been far less clothed than she had been in this instance. Still, she couldn't shake the buzz that tickled the edges of her cheeks and back of her skull. She mentally hit herself for making the choice to change right here in Catra's room. Now she ripped at herself wondering if it was worse to apologize or to say nothing when she left the room.

When she made it back to the living room, Melog had stolen her warmed seat and Catra had set a bowl of noodles and a drink on the coffee table in front of them. She looked up at Adora, mid-bite with her smooth looking legs tucked under.

Adora was touched by the simple gesture of caretaking that Catra had given. Warm tendrils coiled up from the food in the bowl and the drink was still cold from the fridge. Ever since she had moved out on her own, she hadn't had the experience of anyone taking care of her. Glimmer would offer for her to come and cook dinner, but Adora always took it as a debt to be paid off. She would usually accept the food and then help Glimmer intensively organize her clothset or hang a new Ikea shelf for her.

She wasn't sure how to just accept things.

Adora looked up at the tv, now switched over to what looked like Ninja Warrior where people scrambled to make it through obstacle courses in record time to win a title and bragging rights.

"I used to watch this all the time." Adora admitted, lifting her own bowl up to herself. Catra pursed her lips to blow air to cool her meal down.

"Taking notes for your own workout?"

"I mean…"

Adora couldn't remember if she had told Catra that she was consistent in her workouts or if she just gathered it from the mention of coaching. Her carousel of a brain was starting to lull itself more until she wondered if Catra could just tell from seeing her in her underwear that it *looked* like she was fairly active. The idea of being perceived like that made her tense up again.

The three of them sat on the couch, watching a man in an athletic tank and shorts miss a bar by inches and fall into the safety of the water below.

"That would piss me off so much. Getting that close then into the fucking water." Catra commented, shaking her head in pity at the luck of the contestant.

“I bet he’s like five times better the next time he’s on.” Adora said, nearly losing a noodle from her lip. Catra made a sound that caught Adora’s attention, she looked over to see her stifling a giggle at Adora’s attempt to save face.

“Not me, I’d probably go for this once then call it quits.”

They had long since finished their food before Adora realized she had no idea what time it was anymore and that her buzz was almost entirely worn off. Feeling a chill, Catra pulled the knotted afghan to throw over their legs. The warmth made goosebumps for along the length of Adora’s arms. Even Melog had migrated again, now onto Adora’s lap, sitting lazily curled up and purring against her lap.

“What a traitor.” Catra scoffed, sliding herself down the line of the couch next to Adora to scratch her nails gently on the top of Melog’s head.

The sound of keys jingled on the outside of the door before it was pushed open, allowing the other bartender Adora had seen earlier at the bar inside. Her white hair was easy to pick out in the darkness of the entryway.

“Scored some leftover rolls from the kitchen…” Scorpia called out before turning around, surprising herself into a silence from the extra presence in her living room. “Ah, am I interrupting

something…?” she asked, awkwardly stepping back towards the door with her brown paper bag in her gloved hand.

Adora blushed again, slightly relieved that she seemed just as out of her depth as she felt.

“Nah you’re good, there's some more noodles on the stove.” Catra said cooley.

Somewhere inside of Adora deflated when Catra said her roommate wasn’t interrupting anything. It was stupid and didn’t make sense so she just gave a friendly wave when Scorpia walked behind her.

“You’re looking slightly better than the last time I saw you.” Scorpia called to Adora. She wasn’t sure if that was a compliment.

“...Thanks? I’m feeling a little more with it now.” Catra’s roommate left her without a reply, making the anxious blonde wonder if she had done something to upset her. Scorpia walked a roll over to Catra, handing it to her before leaving Adora with one last sentiment.

“Goodnight. Don’t throw up on the couch.”

Adora frowned then looked back at where she had seen Scorpia ascend the stairs. She felt Catra’s leg nudge against hers.

“Don’t worry, she’s just been having a shit week.”

“I think I’m probably good to go home now.” Adora admitted, not wanting to burden Catra with her presence anymore. Catra’s face flattened.

“Oh.” her confident face looked like it was trying to map out a strategy. Adora felt bad that she had even brought it up. “Melog sleeps with me anyway so if you’re worried about-”

“No, I didn’t mean anything by it. I can’t thank you enough for letting me hang out while I get myself together.” Adora’s words tumbled out of her. “It made my friends forcing me to come out worth it.”

The naturally charismatic smile on Catra’s face pulled into something more genuine with Adora’s words. Her eye’s softened and betrayed the air of nonchalance she seemed to always be emitting.

“You made my night better too.”

Their faces were already close before they were interrupted by Scorpia’s return home. Now Melog had scampered off to find a drink from their bowl. Catra didn’t move back, she kept her seat

directly side by side with Adora who agreed to wait one more episode before looking up an Uber on her phone.

It felt natural, the way the two could pull each in on topics about anything. As if they had known each other forever, they bounced from conversations about best concerts to go see, worst places for take-out in the city, and then to mock the contestants on the show that continued to play in the background. Catra told Adora about her first few jobs waitressing and in customer service before landing a spot at the Silver Lotus. Adora told her about her busy weekday schedule. She was up and running from 6am to midnight most days, which prompted an "ew" from her audience member.

"Once I finish my program, things will calm down." Adora sighed, sounding more like she was telling herself than she was Catra.

"So the odds of you coming back to see me at the restaurant are pretty slim huh?" Catra asked, slightly coy and seeming lightly despaired. Her nails plucked at loose strings on the worn couch, she watched her own hands before looking up at Adora like a predator hunting its prey.

"I could make time." Adora whispered. The tension of her pause made the palpitations of Adora's heart feel like they were working without command. Catra's eyes looked down at Adora's mouth, just inches from her own. She tilted her head slightly, her long hair draping against the large nightshirt she had borrowed.

With Catra leaning into her, Adora didn't hesitate to bring her lips closer and pressed them against Catra's. Her heart beat faster and the warmth from being under the blanket, pressed against each other and now the blooming feeling in Adora's chest. Her fingers grazed the exposed skin of Catra's outer thigh as she moved herself closer into her while the brunette pulled her wrist up to cup the side of Adora's face to keep her near.

They broke apart for a second, with Adora now crawled on top of Catra and the blanket tangled on and between them. Her blonde strands strayed off the sides of her head, wisping as she held herself over the gorgeous woman under her. Adora lowered herself back in to bring her mouth with Catra's again. It was like a slow stoking fire had been instantly ignited. Catra's mouth moved against hers so smoothly that Adora nearly convinced herself that she didn't need air anymore.

Black nails carefully tangled themselves in Adora's hair, still pulled up in a now messy ponytail. She couldn't remember the last time she had made out with someone. It was exhilarating, she now knew for a fact that calling an Uber would be the dumbest shit she could possibly do tonight.

After several more heated minutes, Catra trailed her kisses innocently down to Adora's jaw line.

"Stay?" she asked.

"Yeah." Adora agreed, her face beaming as she rested her forehead against Catra's before going in for another kiss.

Chapter End Notes

I'll be real, I don't know what this was other than an fun one shot. Should I keep it going because I think they're adorable?

Going Home

Chapter Summary

> Adora sneaks out, regrets it, then slowly tries to sneak back into Catra's orbit.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

She couldn’t remember the last time she woke up after sunrise.

Warm and cozy under the weight of the blanket, the two were still tangled in each other's hold. Wild brown hair was pressed against the back padding of the couch while Adora lay facing her.

After leaving the Netflix screen abandoned with the words *“are you still watching?”* screen, they could only focus on spending the rest of the night feeding into each other’s touch. Each time Catra tried to break a slow and needy kiss, Adora would softly use her hand to lift her chin back up and to her mouth to feed her own hunger.

It was nice to be able to feed into her own selfish wants and what she had wanted last night was Catra.

The weightless feeling that covered her as she began to stir was bliss and so convincing that it almost made her pull her arms tighter around Catra and close her eyes again.

Then her mind started working.

Like an engine frantically going from coasting to slamming on the accelerator, her eyes widened. It was morning, she hadn't been home, and she still had a ton of cleaning and studying to do if she was going to catch her work out.

Although her mind moved faster than her body, Catra seemed to be able to sense the tensing of the woman beside her and buried herself deeper in the couch and Adora. Breaking such a serene moment of seeing Catra in this light in more ways than one made Adora consider just how long she could get away with putting off her plans for the day.

She looked around, locating her coat and where she had left her clothes before carefully pulling herself from Catra. The more her mind woke itself, the more she knew she had to get going for more reasons than one.

Adora remembered Catra's roommate, who seemed alright but she would prefer not having an awkward morning encounter if she could avoid it.

Even with minimal disturbance, Adora felt like she was too bulky to move as stealthily as she wanted. Her body slid from the couch to silently catch her feet on the ground just to hear Catra let out a sigh as she continued to sleep.

When she crept over to her clothes, she decided the opening and closing of doors to the bathroom would be too much of a

disturbance to give her the clean escape that she wanted. Grabbing her clothes while still adorned with the borrowed sleepwear from her hostess, Adora swiped the screen on for her nearly dead phone.

She was graced with enough battery to open a rideshare app and order a driver to come and pick her up at the nearest crossroads she could see from the online map. Adora sighed while thanking the power of GPSs because she had no idea what the address of Catra's house was.

Adora quieted her footsteps to the best of her ability and went to the door to slide her boots and coat before making brief eye contact with a lazily blinking Melog. The cat sat in the middle of the staircase and offered a nearly inaudible croak of a mewl. The door gave a heavy click as she closed it behind her.

Her phone hadn't given an alert that her ride was there but the air didn't have enough of a bite to bother her. She ripped her hair from her messy ponytail before retying it into a clump of a bun on top of her head. Her teeth had yet to be brushed and she regretted not using the bathroom before she made her great escape but every choice she made felt like she was fumbling her way through what turned out to be a great night in her favor.

There were a few more people out on the street, feeling odd for standing on a street corner without crossing, Adora decided to take her phone out to pretend to fiddle with it. The time was close to nine-thirty, easily the latest she had ever slept in. Her alarms had already gone off and been easily ignored in the form of vibrations and her exercise tracker had sent its gleeful reminders

that she should get to running her two miles that she had neglected.

None of that was a priority to her. What really sat at the forefront of her mind was if she was supposed to say goodbye. She didn't want to bother Catra and wake her up just because she had to leave but now she wondered if it was rude to just disappear in the morning- even if it technically wasn't a one night stand.

Her phone flipped to a black screen as it's last bit of life faded, leaving her starting at a blacked out brick in her hand. She frowned.

Again, she was overthinking it.

Catra would wake up and probably just move on with her day. With or without the added irritation of having her clothes stolen by some girl that she had just met at a bar the night before.

She probably wasn't the first one she had brought home…

Adora's thoughts were cut short by a black toyota pulling up. A small sliver of the window rolled down to confirm she was the one receiving a ride before Adora put on her best social face and climbed into the back. The ride wasn't far and she could always bring the clothes back to Catra now that she knew the approximate area of where she could find her. Her blue eyes were

tired, feeling weighted as she looked out the window on her way back to her apartment.

Would Catra even want to see her again?

At the drop off, Adora thanked her driver and assured her that she would leave a good review once she charged her phone. The woman thanked her, even though she hadn't made the request in the first place. Blonde strands pulled themselves from the hold of her quick up-do, making her look the part of a tired girl who had a little too much of a good time last night.

After unlocking her door and letting herself in, she untied and kicked her boots off and put her dead phone on the charger. A quick trip to the bathroom ultimately led to the decision to take a shower. Having the hot water rush down her skin gave her the potential of being turned back into a real person again. The humidity from the bathroom did a bit of a number on her stomach and once she was cleaned off from a night of sweating, dancing, and being *very* close with someone else she toweled off and wrapped her wet hair up before covering herself to retrieve some sweats.

Rifling through her dresser and closet for something warm and preferably fleece lined, she found a pair of gray sweats and an old red lacrosse shirt from her junior high days that was large enough in size to still fit.

Feeling clean and still a little sluggish, she wanted to climb into the comfort of her own bed and wrap herself up in a squeeze of

fabric. Her brain had decided she hadn't earned that yet- she could rest once she did some studying and correspondence with the lab techs from the university.

Already at the foot of the bed- never too far from her reach, even in sleep was a silver laptop. She leaned to grasp and pull it closer until she was able to bring it to her lap comfortably and power it on to begin clicking in her password and log in information.

The screen came alive with her work that she had been in the middle of. Multiple tabs of homework assignments, reference pages, and several papers nearly completed but still needing the final touches all begged for her attention, willing Adora to choose them. Without the charger, Adora would only have a few precious minutes to make sure no important emails had managed to come through and escape her attention from the connected account on her phone. Seeing all the starred emails made her instantly feel more awake. Sure she was glad to have a night of fun, but now it was time to pull herself back into the real work. She responded to her lab partner about the next day they could meet to run assessments and then began double checking her anatomy notes for the upcoming exam.

Even when her brain wanted a breather, she was incapable of giving that gift.

Her face tensed as she read, then re-read, then re-read *again,* her highlighted notes and diagrams on the hyoid bone and the structures around the neck. She knew each term and the spelling perfectly- or so she thought. Now that she began to quiz herself, all that could come to cloud her mind was thinking about the soft curves of the neck, a neck belonging to Catra.

Adora switched gears, trying to throw in her airpods to listen to a recorded lecture and hoping the information would absorb that way. Again, the same issue persisted. She tapped the screen several times to rewind and replay sections where the words refused to stay with her for more than a few fleeting seconds. She shook her head in self disapproval, figuring she was still hung over and needing something to drink to focus.

She carefully closed her device and slid it off her lap in temporary defeat. An irritating break to grab a protein drink from the kitchen as she re-tied her ponytail tighter was her next approach. Once she was in a better headspace, she'd be back on her game. After grabbing the vanilla flavored drink, Adora straightened up and looked over to her phone that had plugged in on the counter.

It had returned to life and thankfully had been set to vibrate. She could hear the phone buzz, reminding her to not only pick it up now but that it would be wise to make sure she didn't send anything embarrassing last night. The thought made her cringe at herself before she was even sure.

With one hand holding her beverage, she flipped over her phone in her hand as it stayed tethered to the wall.

Glimmer's picture and name flashed on the screen, calling Adora to answer.

Adora swiped to accept. "Hey,".

“Adora! Oh my- thank God you’re not dead!” her bubble voice sounded like several levels of relief.

“Only feel like it.” Adora murmured.

“We didn’t know if you were in an ice bath with a kidney stolen or something! Where are you?” she probed quickly, almost sounding as if she were concerned about time.

“No Glim, I’m home now. Sorry, I should have called earlier.” guilt pinged at Adora. She capped her drink and gave it a few absent minded shakes to mix it contents.

Glimmer sighed, relieving her own stress. “It’s okay, you’re okay. And you’re home? Did you Uber?”.

Adora unscrewed the cap as she let her friend work through her multiple questions, knowing she wasn’t ready for a reply yet.

“-Bow kept insisting you would be fine but I felt weird like I made the wrong call on letting you go.”

“I can promise I’m alive with all my organs.” Adora chuckled, amused at how fast her friend’s mind worked its way through

emotions. She heard a satisfied sigh from the other end before an extended pause.

"...so…?"

Adora raised her eyebrows, knowing full well what it was Glimmer wanted to know. "So…?"

"Come on- how was your night?" Glimmer asked coyly. Even though Adora knew it was coming, she was still on the verge of a blush.

"It was good." she fought to keep her voice steady and try to sound indifferent.

"And…?" Glimmer pulled.

"And now I'm home." Adora closed, not wanting to gush over something that was probably very casual to anyone else.

"Adora, please. Come on" her friend's voice begged on the other end of the call. "Was it fun? Are you going to see her again?".

She paused, like she was a statue in her own home.

“I don’t know.” she answered honestly.

The reply was not the one that Glimmer had been fishing for. “Oh.”

Though her friend could be a little pushy at times, she had enough social grace to know when to ease up.

“Well we should meet up for brunch. You know those health drinks don’t count as an actual meal.” Adora eyed the half finished one in her other hand.

“I gotta catch up on some studying and get prepped for the week.” the second of silence made Adora feel bad about turning her friend down “...sorry.”.

Glimmer sounded accepting. “No, I got my time in the sun yesterday. I should take my wins when I can. Let me know if your lab breaks line up better than last week and maybe we can meet later, okay?”.

“Yeah, sounds good.” Adora smiled softly. She was always grateful for the patience of her friends.

“Love you!” Glimmer added sweetly.

“Love you too, bye” Adora smiled warmly as she ended the call.

With the phone still in her hand, she could see other notifications across the top banner. There were a few texts from her friends, Glimmer asking for multiple updates and access to her location from this morning and Perfuma sending a few pictures of all of them throughout the night with smiles plastered across their faces. There was also a messaged from Bow asking if she had made it home and surprisingly, one from Mermista.

“ *you guys married yet?”*

The message was sent late last night and hooked Adora enough to send a quick response.

“haha no, home now though.” she tapped back, not expecting an answer.

“with a new last name? 😌 *”*

Adora had rinsed her drink and was headed back to the work she left on her bed. *“What the hell?”* she wondered. Mermista never took an interest in anything she did or didn’t do.

She returned back to the bed, still feeling the need to defend herself. Her thumbs typed back quickly after thinking of a decent

response.

"I dont think I even know her last name"

She watched three dots bob up and down on the screen as Mermista typed a reply.

"learn it next time"

Adora blinked at the surprising encouragement from her friend. She remembered that she and Mermista shared a lot of laughs and she learned some new stories about Mermista last night at the bar but didn't think that warranted the total change in dynamic.

Next time? Adora was sure that Mermista would have been the one to advise the three day rule before she texted, called, or tried to contact Catra again.

"you think there might be a next time?" her message looked at her unsent before she deleted it in favor of something less desperate.

Deciding between not replying at all, sent an emoji of a shrug then tucked her phone away to head back to the comfort of her bed.

She knew the general location of Catra's and knew that returning to the restaurant wouldn't be too odd since it was normal to go to a place of business. Then Adora remembered that it was her first experience being in a gay bar and maybe that was her hang up. She could just like the atmosphere and the friendly staffing of *all* of the bars and just never knew it because she hadn't been before. She batted her own thoughts away, immediately telling herself that someone offering their home to a drunk stranger was definitely out of the norm of good customer service.

Catra had to have been interested too and that was a thought that made her heart zip and heart pound.

Looking at the vocabulary for stylohyoid, thyrohyoid, and being able to break down the distinctions, only half of the information seemed to reach a place where it would be retained.

Her mind was still at Catra's and she decided just to get her mind back on track, she silently agreed to herself that she would eventually go back to the bar to return the borrowed clothes and say thank you. Maybe stay for a drink if she didn't make an ass out of herself.

Her head nodded in agreement to her own plan.

The rest of the afternoon and evening was spent drowning herself in the never ending tidal wave of obligations and self-set

expectations. She looked over her course books and notes until she had each diagram memorized and could explain each concept backwards, forwards, and in her sleep.

She looked at her smart watch, noting and feeling simultaneously relieved that after she completed her correspondence with her peers at the lab, she could squeeze in a late evening run and be encouraged to trim her time down if she wanted to make it home before dark.

Adora switched her clothes to a pair of tight fitting exercise capris and a workout tank. Leaving her house, she pushed her phone down into her pocket and put in her headphones before she began stretching out her calf muscles just outside of her front door. She tightened her hair up one last time before starting out with a strong stride to veer right and head down the sidewalk.

Her playlist was upbeat, she liked most of her songs to maintain a good beat to keep her pace quick and steady. Rihanna, P!nk, and other pop artists kept her in a great stride where she was entirely confident she could easily complete a mile in under fifteen minutes. Adora liked running more than lifting and more structured workouts because she was able to just power off her mind and only think about her breathing, the burn of her lungs, and keeping each foot kicked out in front of the other in a balanced movement.

For each thump of her shoe on the pavement, her mind finally stayed clear. She approached a crosswalk bearing the red symbol to indicate for her to wait for traffic to clear. Lifting her two fingers to check her pulse against what her fitness app read, she began

to pull back into real life and realized her playlist had shifted to a new suggestion she didn't recognize from her usual workout mix.

The unfamiliar lyrics crooned:

I can still smell you on my clothes

I should have known, I guess we're both sinners,

We're both sinners

The words making her heart rate pick up, she scrambled to her phone to switch songs to try and keep something more generic playing that wouldn't make her think more about the virtual stranger she had agreed to give space to. It was already on the edge of her mind to take her run right past The Silver Lotus to see if she was working but thought that would be near stalking behavior.

She went to take a step off to the side, not having noticed that the light had turned into the white outline of a person walking for her to go ahead. She also failed to see the bike cruising up behind her that was unable to stop.

"HEY!" a voice screeched before Adora felt metal handlebars catch her side. Thankfully it wasn't a head on impact, but it was enough to hurt and make Adora yell in surprise. The girl and her bike

swerved and nearly toppled but the purple haired rider was able to plant her feet on the ground and save herself. A package of some sort went flying off of the back, previously held on by a too loose bungee cord and now laying partially splattered across the sidewalk in front of the other apartments and hobby shops.

Even with the pain still active, Adora held her side. Assume it would just be a nice bruise at the end of the day.

“Shit, I’m sorry about that. I didn’t- I wasn’t-.” Adora admitted as the bike rider pulled her goggles from over her eyes. She plucked an earbud from her ear.

“Wow, just lucky I didn’t have the engine on. Guess that’s why they say not to kick it on when in the city limits.” she mused to herself, not seemingly to actually speak to Adora. “You know that means it’s time for you to cross right?”.

She took a breath, noticing that the girl’s tone seemed genuine. She actually thought the reason Adora didn’t move might have been because she was misinformed on what to do at a crosswalk.

“No- I got that. I was just looking at my phone and should have been paying attention.

“Ah. Okay yeah. Must be a runner. I see lots of different types on my deliveries so you never know.” she shrugged. The girls bike seemed to be a homemade contraption that looked decently

constructed. There were pedals like a normal bike but armed with the comments from before, Adora was able to pick out a small engine under the bar where her seat was. The frame was colored in black and purple colors with a small flat rack on the back that now sat empty. The girl seemed to finally notice and her focused eyes scavenged around to quickly spot the casualty of what once was food off to the side of the walkway.

"Another package lost? Catra isn't going to be happy with this again…"

"Catra?" Adora caught her words quickly as if they were tossed to her underhandedly. "Do you work over at the bar with her?". They question sprung from Adora's mouth before she could stop it.

"I don't work *in* the restaurant . Just delivery mostly. But I seem to be having some bad luck recently and this is about to be the third time I've lost an order." she seemed more troubled by the lack in her work consistency than whatever the actual consequence would be.

"I'm sure it'll be alright. It was my fault anyway, I can call and tell them that if your manager or whoever has an issue." Adora offered. She didn't want this poor delivery girl to get in trouble because she couldn't keep her mind out of the gutter and off of the thought of Catra for more than an hour.

Her face beamed and she flung a long pigtail over her shoulder before giving a grateful wave.

“Thanks! I’m sorry if you’re a regular. I don’t interact with a lot of the dine in customers so I don’t know if I should recognize you." The tone of her voice was so blunt but with no edge of anger or defense in it.

“I’ve only been in once, last night actually. But I do have a favor to ask you…feel free to say ‘no’.” Adora’s bold plan dissolved to a slight mumble as she found what she wanted to say. “Can you give Catra my number? I don’t want to be weird but she helped me out last night and I wanted to give a better thank you…”.

“Sure.” she agreed immediately. Adora was surprised but pleased with how easy it was to get the driver’s help without doing any convincing. She had mentally prepared a ten reason long list on why she wasn’t a danger and she only had good intentions.

“What’s your name by the way?” Adora asked as the girl took out her phone.

“Entrapta. But I hope you’re not confused in thinking that she’s my boss. We’re more like co-workers. I can pass your message along though.” she nodded as Adora read and then repeated her number to Entrapta. A text instantly came through from a new number with the simple greeting of “hi”.

Adora typed back: “hey, its adora 🙄”

Entrapa nodded after scraping up the splattered food and crushing it into a nearby trash bin to the best of her ability before pedaling on her way.

Even with the pain in her ribs and her mile time ruined, Adora was feeling like it was the most successful run she had ever had.

Chapter End Notes

The song was Sinners by Ari Abdul ft. Thomas LaRosa.

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